

What Is Missing in Our Modern Understanding of Health?

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स्वस्थस्य स्वास्थ्यरक्षणम् आतुरस्य विकारप्रशमनं च।

--- चरकसंहिता, सूत्रस्थान (३०.२६)

The purpose of Āyurveda is twofold: to preserve the health of the healthy and to alleviate the disorders of the diseased. - Caraka Samhitā Sūtrasthāna (30.26)

Most of us believe we understand what it means to be healthy. We are told to eat a balanced diet, exercise regularly, avoid intoxicants, undergo periodic medical checkups, and trust our medical reports. If the blood tests are normal, the cholesterol is under control, the ECG looks fine, and the MRI or CT scan shows nothing unusual, we naturally conclude that we are healthy. Yet many people with perfectly "normal" reports continue to feel "abnormal" -fatigued, mentally exhausted, anxious, bloated, or simply unwell. This suggests that while modern medicine is extraordinarily successful at diagnosing and treating disease, it may not completely capture every dimension of health. Āyurveda begins precisely at this point. It asks not only whether disease is present, but whether the body is functioning in balance every single day. The following sections present some interesting differences in perspective.

Health Is Defined Primarily by Reports, Statistics, and Numbers

General Perception. Health is commonly assessed using measurable parameters such as blood investigations, cholesterol levels, BMI, blood pressure, imaging studies, and other diagnostic tests. If these values fall within the normal range, one is generally considered healthy.

Think and Ponder. How many laboratory tests exist for the human body? Is it practical to undergo all of them regularly? Can every disease be detected before symptoms appear? Do laboratory reports fully explain why a person feels unwell despite "normal" findings?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda considers laboratory investigations valuable, but not sufficient. It asks additional questions. Do you wake up refreshed? Is your digestion comfortable? Is your energy steady throughout the day? Is your mind calm? According to Āyurveda, health is not merely a normal laboratory report. Disease often develops gradually, long before measurable abnormalities become apparent.

Balanced Diet Is Often Reduced to Nutrient Arithmetic

General Perception. A balanced diet is frequently understood as consuming the correct amounts of proteins, carbohydrates, fats, vitamins, minerals, and calories.

Think and Ponder. Do all people digest food equally well? Can two individuals obtain the same nourishment from the same meal? What happens when digestion or absorption is poor?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda distinguishes between eating food and being nourished by it. Health depends not only upon what is consumed, but also upon what is digested, absorbed, assimilated, and utilized. Even excellent food cannot nourish the body if digestion is impaired.

Elimination Is Rarely Considered Part of Health

General Perception. Health discussions usually focus on food intake, nutrition, and energy production.

Think and Ponder. What happens to material that the body cannot assimilate? How important is proper elimination for long-term health? Can poor elimination gradually affect overall well-being?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda views health as a continuous balance of three processes: proper intake, proper assimilation, and proper elimination. Failure of any one of these disturbs physiological balance.

One-Size-Fits-All Health Advice

General Perception. General recommendations often promote identical diet plans, exercise routines, and ideal body measurements for everyone.

Think and Ponder. Do people really have identical constitutions, digestive capacities, lifestyles, climates, ages, and stress levels?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda recognizes every individual as biologically unique. What benefits one person may not benefit another. Diet, lifestyle, and treatment should therefore be individualized rather than universally prescribed.

Lifestyle Is Treated as an Optional Extra

General Perception. Health advice frequently revolves around eating healthy food and exercising regularly.

Think and Ponder. When do you sleep? How regular are your meals? How much stress fills your day? How much time do you spend on screens? Does your daily routine support recovery?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda considers lifestyle to be one of the principal determinants of health. Food, sleep, daily routine, work habits, and mental discipline together determine long-term well-being. No medicine can permanently compensate for an unhealthy way of life.

The Mind Is Often Treated Separately from the Body

General Perception. Stress, anxiety, poor sleep, and emotional exhaustion are often accepted as unavoidable features of modern life.

Think and Ponder. Can prolonged mental stress influence digestion, immunity, sleep, energy, and physical health?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda regards the mind and body as inseparable. Persistent emotional disturbance eventually manifests physically. Maintaining mental balance is therefore considered essential for maintaining physical health.

Prevention Is Reduced to Periodic Checkups

General Perception. Preventive healthcare commonly consists of annual health examinations, screening tests, and diagnostic investigations.

Think and Ponder. Is prevention something that happens once every year? Or does it occur every day through eating, sleeping, working, responding to stress, and adapting to the environment?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda considers prevention to be a continuous process. Every meal, every night's sleep, every daily habit, and every response to life's challenges either preserves health or gradually disturbs it.

Disease Is Viewed Fragmentarily Rather Than Systemically

General Perception. Modern clinical practice often focuses on identifying affected organs, diagnosing disease, and treating specific symptoms.

Think and Ponder. Why did the disease begin? How did it progress? Could its progression have been interrupted earlier? Is treating symptoms alone sufficient to restore health?

Āyurvedic Correction. Āyurveda emphasizes understanding the origin and progression of disease. It views illness as a gradual disturbance of the body's internal balance rather than a sudden isolated event. True healing therefore requires understanding the underlying process rather than merely suppressing its manifestations.